SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #47 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“A good woman puts everyone else first.”

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Where it often comes from

Girls often learn to be helpful, agreeable, and self-sacrificing. Mothers modeling endless giving, church examples of serving, and praise for “selflessness” can leave women exhausted and resentful, unsure whether they are permitted needs of their own.

What Scripture teaches

Paul urges, “in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others.” Notice “not only.” Jesus said to love your neighbor “as yourself,” which assumes caring for yourself. Jesus Himself withdrew to rest and pray. The woman of Proverbs 31 buys fields, manages her household, and “opens her mouth with wisdom.” Serving others is godly. Erasing yourself is not what Scripture asks.

> *“Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others”* (Philippians 2:3–4).

Also see

> “Strength and honor are her clothing, and she can laugh at the days to come. She opens her mouth with wisdom, and faithful instruction is on her tongue” (Proverbs 31:25–26).

> “So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them” (Genesis 1:27).

> “For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you” (Romans 12:3).

> “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus” (Galatians 3:28).

Common self-statements

- If I take time for me, I am selfish.
- Everyone else comes first.
- My needs do not count.
- A good woman never says no.
- I must keep everyone happy.
- I am responsible for others’ happiness.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either selfless or selfish.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will think I am selfish.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I am wrong to rest.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that everything will fall apart if I say no.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that goodness means self-erasure?
- What does Scripture say about looking to others' interests "not only" my own?
- What happens to me when I never rest?
- What would I tell my daughter or a friend?
- What would a healthy balance look like?
- What is one need I can meet this week?

Truth summary

> I am a person made in God's image, with worth and needs. Serving is good, and so is rest, boundaries, and care for myself. Loving my neighbor as myself includes myself.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Tired
- Humility
- Love, For Others
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "A good woman puts everyone else first"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A good woman puts everyone else first." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ What does "not only" mean?
- ☐ What happens when I never rest?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What balance is healthy?
- ☐ What need can I meet?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am made in God's image.
- ☐ Look to others' interests, not only my own.
- ☐ Love your neighbor as yourself.
- ☐ Rest is godly.
- ☐ I can say no.
- ☐ My needs matter too.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Philippians 2:3–4**
  "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others."
- ☐ **Genesis 1:27**
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ **Romans 12:3**
  "For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Care for myself too: Each week, note one need you met and one kind no.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Philippians 2:3–4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can care for others' interests and my own.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List your needs. Write what you need in body, mind, and spirit.
- ☐ Say one kind no. Decline one thing this week.
- ☐ Schedule rest. Block an hour for yourself.
- ☐ Read Mark 12:31. Notice "as yourself."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A good woman puts everyone else first": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Care for myself too
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A good woman puts everyone else first.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have poured out until I am empty. Teach me to serve with joy, rest with permission, and care for the life You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.